



The file cabinet metaphor

are the training wheels that have ushered us into the new era. Now we're familiar enough with computers to do away with painfully obvious visual metaphors, and roll out cleaner, more functional designs. The training wheels are finally off, and although this particular analogy has come to its end, skeuomorphism certainly hasn't. A good design is a combination of good visual metaphors and efficient functionality, and if used correctly, skeuomorphs still have a place in contemporary design.

Flat design

The past two years in the world of technology design have seen a marked shift away from familiarity and an increased emphasis on functionality. Google Trends confirms that searches for "flat design" started skyrocketing in early 2013, while by mid-2014, Google's own "Material Design" philosophy was beginning to take the internet by storm. Android and iOS – the most popular mobile operating systems today – both follow a flat design philosophy.

From imitation to flattery

We saw that skeuomorphism involved imitation of real-world counterparts of on-screen elements. This led to an aggressive emphasis on the three-dimensionality of objects on-screen. Some of the most obvious examples are – bulging buttons; shiny, rounded icons; and switches popping up and down depending on their on/off state. The fact that our screens were two-